

AI-HED · BEST PRACTICE · PILOT COURSE

Gamification in Public Relations Strategies

How AI was integrated as a creative and research support tool in a final-year elective at the School of Communication and Media Studies, Polytechnic University of Lisbon.

INFORMANT

ANTÓNIO AZEVEDO

INTERVIEW

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INSTITUTION

ESCS · IPL · LISBON



COURSE AT A GLANCE

A final-year elective at the intersection of PR, gaming, and esports

5

ECTS CREDITS

17

STUDENTS

5th

SEMESTER

BA

BACHELOR LEVEL

COURSE OVERVIEW

Gamification in Public Relations Strategies

UNIVERSITY

**School of Communication and Media
Studies — Polytechnic University of
Lisbon**

PROGRAMME

**Public Relations and Corporate
Communication**

COURSE LEVEL

Bachelor · 5th semester · 5 ECTS

TYPICAL STUDENT BACKGROUND

Final-year undergraduates with a solid grasp of communication and strategic PR principles. As an elective, the course attracts students with a particular interest in gaming, esports, and emerging digital communication environments.

PREREQUISITES

None — beyond enrolment in the Bachelor's programme.

SUMMARY OF AI USAGE

AI was integrated into the course as a creative and research support tool across several practical exercises and project development stages. Students used AI tools mainly for ideation, research, and structuring communication strategies within the gaming and esports ecosystem. The primary goal was to help students explore ideas faster while learning to critically evaluate and refine AI-generated outputs. A distinctive element was the combination of hands-on creative tasks (e.g., campaign ideation, customized campaign song commercials, and mind mapping) with structured reflection on the limitations and responsible use of AI.

— ANTÓNIO AZEVEDO, COURSE COORDINATOR

SECTION 02

02

Learning outcomes

What the course set out to teach — and where AI made a difference.

INTENDED LEARNING OUTCOMES

What are the learning outcomes of the course?

1. *Describe the cultural relevance and economic impact of the gaming and esports industries.*
2. *Identify communication challenges and opportunities for brands in gaming environments.*
3. *Evaluate communication platforms, channels, and content formats used in gaming.*
4. *Design strategic communication plans adapted to gaming communities.*
5. *Create campaign proposals for endemic and non-endemic brands within the gaming ecosystem.*
6. *Analyse esports as a professional communication and branding environment.*
7. *Investigate emerging trends in gaming and assess implications for brand strategies.*

AI SUPPORT · ILO 1

Accelerating discovery of cases and context

01**INTENDED LEARNING
OUTCOME**

**Describe the cultural
relevance and economic
weight of the gaming and
esports sectors.**

AI tools supported early research stages by helping students identify relevant case studies, examples of brand activations, and recent developments in the gaming industry. Students used AI mainly to accelerate the discovery of examples and contextual information, which were later discussed and validated in class through traditional research and group discussion.

AI SUPPORT · ILO 3

Comparing platforms, channels, and content formats

03

**INTENDED LEARNING
OUTCOME**

**Evaluate different
communication
platforms, channels and
content formats used in
gaming.**

AI helped students explore the communication potential of different platforms and formats used in gaming, such as livestreaming, creator collaborations, and in-game activations. By interacting with AI tools, students were able to quickly generate comparative insights and identify possible strategic uses of different channels, which were then refined through discussion and critical evaluation.

AI SUPPORT · ILO 4

Brainstorming strategic plans for gaming communities

04

INTENDED LEARNING OUTCOME

**Design strategic
communication plans
adapted to gaming
communities.**

AI was mainly used during the ideation phase of strategic exercises. Students interacted with AI tools to brainstorm communication approaches, campaign narratives, and engagement strategies adapted to gaming audiences. These initial AI-supported drafts were later refined through class discussion, peer feedback, and instructor guidance to ensure strategic relevance and originality.

AI SUPPORT · ILO 5

Generating campaign concepts for endemic and non-endemic brands

05

**INTENDED LEARNING
OUTCOME**

Create campaign proposals for endemic and non-endemic brands activating within the gaming ecosystem.

AI supported the creative development of campaign concepts, including brand activations, collaborations with gaming creators, and branded content ideas. Students used AI to explore different creative directions and storytelling possibilities before refining their final proposals. The focus remained on using AI as a support tool for ideation rather than as a replacement for students' own strategic thinking.

SKILLS ENHANCED

Were there specific skills or knowledge areas enhanced by AI?

I believe AI helped strengthen skills in creative ideation and strategic thinking. Students also improved their ability to structure prompts, evaluate AI-generated outputs critically, and refine ideas through iterative interaction with AI tools. Additionally, AI supported faster contextualization of communication challenges within the gaming ecosystem.

AI-SPECIFIC LEARNING OUTCOMES

Does the course have any AI-specific learning outcomes?

No.

The course did not include specific AI-focused learning outcomes. AI was integrated primarily as a supporting tool to help students achieve existing course learning outcomes related to research, ideation, and strategic communication within the gaming ecosystem. However, an implicit objective of the course was to help students develop a more informed and critical approach to AI usage. Through practical exercises and discussions, students were encouraged to improve their prompting skills, understand the limitations of AI-generated outputs, and recognize AI as a support tool that enhances - rather than replaces - critical thinking and creativity.

SECTION 03

03

Purpose & benefits

Why bring AI into this course — and what students and lecturer got out of it.

MAIN MOTIVATION

What was the main reason for using AI in the course?

The main motivation was pedagogical: to expose students to AI as a tool increasingly present in communication and in the creative industries. As part of the pilot programme, the goal was also to explore how AI could be meaningfully integrated into teaching and enhance the overall learning experience. Students were encouraged to experiment with AI while developing awareness of its potential, limitations, and role as a support tool rather than a replacement for critical thinking.

BENEFITS FOR STUDENTS

What were the benefits of AI for the students in the course, if any?

AI allowed students to experiment with innovative tools that are increasingly present in the professional landscape. By interacting with these technologies, students improved both their practical use of AI and their critical awareness of its limitations and potential biases. AI also supported the creative process, helping students explore a wider range of ideas when developing campaign concepts and communication strategies. In many cases, it helped students overcome creative blocks and accelerate early ideation stages. At the same time, class discussions and feedback encouraged students to critically evaluate AI-generated outputs, reinforcing the importance of human judgment.

BENEFITS FOR THE LECTURER

What were the benefits of AI for the lecturers in the course, if any?

I would say AI did not significantly simplify the preparation or delivery of teaching activities. As this was a pilot programme, integrating AI into the course actually required additional planning, experimentation, and attention. However, the process of exploring how AI could be well integrated into classroom activities encouraged reflection on new teaching approaches. Designing exercises that incorporated AI tools helped identify alternative ways to engage students, stimulate creativity, and structure learning activities. In that sense, the experience contributed to pedagogical development by prompting me to rethink certain teaching methods and experiment with new formats that may enrich the learning experience beyond more traditional approaches.

SECTION 04

04

Implementation details

How AI showed up in class — the tools, the access model, and the guidance around them.

HOW AI WAS USED IN CLASS

How was AI used in class?

AI was mainly integrated through in-class practical exercises designed around scenarios that simulated real-world communication briefs. Students were encouraged to use AI tools to support research, explore creative directions, and structure initial ideas while working on campaign concepts related to gaming and esports. These exercises were typically conducted during class time to allow guidance, discussion, and critical evaluation of AI-generated outputs.

AI was also used as support for the main group project, mainly for mind mapping.

TOOLS & PLATFORMS

Which tools or platforms were used?

**GENERAL-PURPOSE GENERATIVE AI****ChatGPT**

Used throughout the course — both during in-class exercises and while developing final communication projects.

**AI MUSIC GENERATION****Suno**

Used in a specific in-class exercise — generating customised campaign song commercials.

**VISUAL STRUCTURING****MindMap AI**

Used in a practical exercise to help students structure and visualise ideas for the final communication plan project.

All tools are web-based and accessible through standard browsers — only basic devices (laptops or smartphones with internet access) are required.

ACCESS · FREE VS PAID

How did the students access the AI tools? (free vs paid versions)

Free

RECOMMENDED FOR ALL
STUDENTS

All tools used in the course offered free versions — the recommended option to ensure equal access.

All AI tools used in the course offered free versions, which were the recommended option for students to ensure equal access. However, there was no real control over whether some students chose to use paid versions (e.g., ChatGPT Plus).

The evaluation of AI-related activities focused primarily on how students used the tools, rather than on the final output, ensuring that access to paid features did not create an advantage in assessment.

GUIDANCE & SUPPORT

What guidance or support was provided to students for using AI effectively?

Guidance was mainly provided during in-class exercises where AI tools were used. Before starting the activities, students received recommendations on how to use the tools effectively, including basic prompting practices and how to provide context to obtain more relevant outputs. During the exercises, I offered support and clarification when needed. At the end of the activities, results were discussed collectively, encouraging students to reflect on the outputs, identify limitations, and explore how prompts could be refined to obtain more personalized and strategically useful results.

AI IN ASSESSMENT

Was the AI usage part of the course assessment?

YES

Part of continuous assessment

AI usage was included as part of the continuous assessment through the in-class exercises. In in-class exercises where the use of AI was required, evaluation focused less on the final output and more on how students used the tools. Students were assessed on the depth of their interaction with AI, the quality of their prompts, and their ability to critically evaluate and refine AI-generated suggestions.

SECTION 05

05

Evaluation & risk management

How impact was measured — and how misuse was kept in check.

HOW IMPACT WAS EVALUATED

How was the impact of AI on teaching and learning evaluated?

At the beginning of the course, students completed a pre-survey to assess their prior knowledge and usage of AI tools. At the end of the semester, a post-survey was conducted to understand how their perceptions and practices had evolved. Additionally, a focus group was organized with students from several courses participating in the pilot programme.

At the same time, feedback was being collected throughout the semester from the students.

METRICS & KPIS

Were there metrics or KPIs (e.g., grades, engagement levels) to monitor success?

NOT REALLY

No predefined quantitative metrics or KPIs were used to measure the impact of AI integration. Instead, the evaluation relied on qualitative insights gathered from the pre- and post-course surveys, as well as informal student feedback collected throughout the course and also during the focus group discussions.

FORMAL COURSE EVALUATION

Was the use of AI part of the formal (e.g. institutional) course evaluation?

NO

Outside the institution's standard process

The course is part of a pilot programme exploring the integration of AI in higher education. Therefore, the use of AI was not included in the institution's standard course evaluation process that applies to all courses. Instead, AI integration was assessed separately within the scope of the AI-HED project through dedicated surveys and feedback activities.

RISK MANAGEMENT

Was there any risk management in place with respect to AI usage?

YES

In-class exercises by design

Most AI usage took place during in-class exercises, which allowed to monitor how students interacted with the tools and ensure that AI supported learning rather than replacing critical thinking. This approach helped prevent passive use or over-reliance on AI. Students were also asked to share and discuss their prompts and interaction process, meaning that assessment focused on how AI was used rather than only on the final outcome. This helped reinforce responsible use and encouraged students to critically evaluate AI-generated outputs. I would say that conducting AI-supported activities in a supervised classroom setting proved effective in maintaining engagement and preventing misuse of the tools.

SECTION 06

06

Overall impact

What changed — for the teaching, the learning, and the student work.

Overall, what was the impact of AI on teaching and learning?

Overall, I would say the impact of AI on teaching and learning was positive. The results were in line with expectations: when used appropriately, AI helped students explore a wider range of ideas and potential solutions, particularly during creative and strategic exercises. It supported ideation and encouraged experimentation, which contributed to student engagement. However, it did not radically transform the learning process. For me, integrating AI definitely brought additional responsibility in ensuring that the tools were used appropriately and did not become a substitute for critical thinking or student effort. Managing this balance required attention and carefulness.

— COURSE COORDINATOR'S REFLECTION

IMPACT ON STUDENT LEARNING OUTCOMES

To what extent did AI impact student learning outcomes?

AI had a moderate but positive impact on student learning outcomes. It helped students accelerate the contextualization and research phases of their work, allowing them to gather relevant examples and insights more efficiently. In several cases, AI also contributed to enriching projects by suggesting additional creative directions or strategic possibilities. However, the strongest ideas consistently originated from the students themselves, with AI mainly serving as a tool to expand, refine, and deepen those initial concepts. Overall, AI functioned as a complementary support that enhanced students' exploration and development of ideas rather than fundamentally changing their core learning outcomes.

MAIN CHALLENGES & HOW THEY WERE MANAGED

Overall, which were the main challenges? And how were they managed?

The main challenge was ensuring that students did not simply input the assignment brief into AI tools and ask them to generate complete solutions. In some cases, similar prompts produced very similar responses among students, which highlighted superficial or overly dependent use of AI. These situations were addressed directly with students, using them as examples to explain why this approach limited learning outcomes. In short, the strategy to manage this challenge was continuous reinforcement of proper AI usage, emphasizing that the tools should support ideation and exploration rather than replace student effort. Individual feedback and class discussions were used to encourage deeper prompting, more critical evaluation of outputs, and greater personalization of AI-assisted work.

SECTION 07

07

Scalability & transferability

How this experience travels to other courses — and what it would take to support that.

SCALING TO OTHER COURSES

Can this experience be scaled to other courses? If yes, what resources or institutional support would be required to scale this experience?

AI is already a reality in basically all professional fields and can be relevant to a wide range of academic disciplines. While different courses may benefit from exploring different AI tools depending on their field, the overall approach can be easily adapted. One important requirement would be the development of institutional guidelines for responsible AI use, helping students and teachers understand good practices and ethical considerations across all courses. Additionally, as AI adoption grows, institutions could support this integration by providing access to selected AI tools through institutional licenses or educational partnerships, ensuring that students have equitable access to platforms that may otherwise have limitations in their free versions.

KEY ADVICE FOR EDUCATORS

What key advice would you give to other educators?

Educators should first take time to familiarize themselves with the AI tools they plan to introduce, understanding both their capabilities and limitations. In classroom activities, it is useful to focus on how students use AI in the process, rather than only evaluating the final outcome. Demonstrating good examples of AI use during class can also help students understand how the tools can support their work. Finally, it is important to provide continuous feedback and intervene when students rely on AI as a shortcut rather than using it to genuinely enhance their thinking and learning process.

THANK YOU

A pilot that opened space for ideation — without losing the student's own voice.

COURSE

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INFORMANT

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Azevedo

INSTITUTION

ESCS · Polytechnic University of
Lisbon

PROGRAMME

AI-HED ·
Erasmus+

ABOUT THE PROJECT

Artificial Intelligence in Higher Education Teaching and Learning

The project “Artificial Intelligence in Higher Education Teaching and Learning” (AI-HED) - 2024-1-NL01-KA220-HED-000248874, launched with co-funding from the European Commission under the Erasmus+ Programme in the fields of education, training, youth, and sport for the 2021-2027 period, was submitted and awarded under Key Action 2: Cooperation among organisations and institutions.

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